

# ACROSS THE Empire

## LIFE UNDER ROMAN RULE

In 27 BCE, having won a civil war, Octavian (later given the title Augustus) became the first ruler of the Roman Empire. Until its fall in 476 CE in the West, its vast territories were ruled by emperors, first in Rome and later in Constantinople. This brought a diverse range of peoples under the control of Rome, whose laws were enforced across its empire. Defining issues such as slavery, concubinage, and marriage, Roman laws affected the lives of millions of men and women.

During the period of the empire, Roman women remained unable to vote or hold political office, but progressively gained some independence; girls from aristocratic families could receive an education at home and women could write their own will and also appear in court as their own advocate. With the abandonment of *cum manu* marriage (see pp. 32–33), husbands no longer gained control of their wife's property; wives remained under the control of their *pater familias*—the oldest male in their family. When a woman's father died, she became independent and could inherit property as her brothers did.

### Citizens and slaves

Although women did not have any political power, some still exerted influence as a result of their high social status. Born in 58 BCE, Livia Drusilla was the third wife of Emperor Augustus, and often gave him advice. He gave her the right to manage her own affairs in 35 BCE, raised a public statue in her honor, and granted her the title of Julia Augusta (a great woman of the

**17.9**  
years was the  
average life  
expectancy  
for a female  
slave in Rome

Julian family) in his will to secure her position after his death. Livia, however, was an unusual case in a culture ruled by *patres familias*.

The average woman probably spent her days cooking; caring for and educating the children; and sewing or spinning, which was an important part of women's lives. With the advent of the empire, upper-class women could now leave textile work to their slaves, who were typically war captives from lands conquered by Rome, such as Britain, Greece, Syria, and North Africa. Male slaves from educated backgrounds tended to work in skilled professions, whereas women were typically domestic servants. How female slaves were treated depended on the temperament of their owners. Some suffered at the hands of predatory masters and bore their children. Any child born of a slave by her master was a slave; the master could free that child but not acknowledge or adopt it. Enslaved women

### ► Sabine women

In Roman mythology, its soldiers abducted and forcibly married women of the Sabine tribe. However, in reality, soldiers of the Roman Empire raped women in the lands they conquered and saw them simply as spoils of war, not potential brides.

